

Mute swan

Cygnus olor

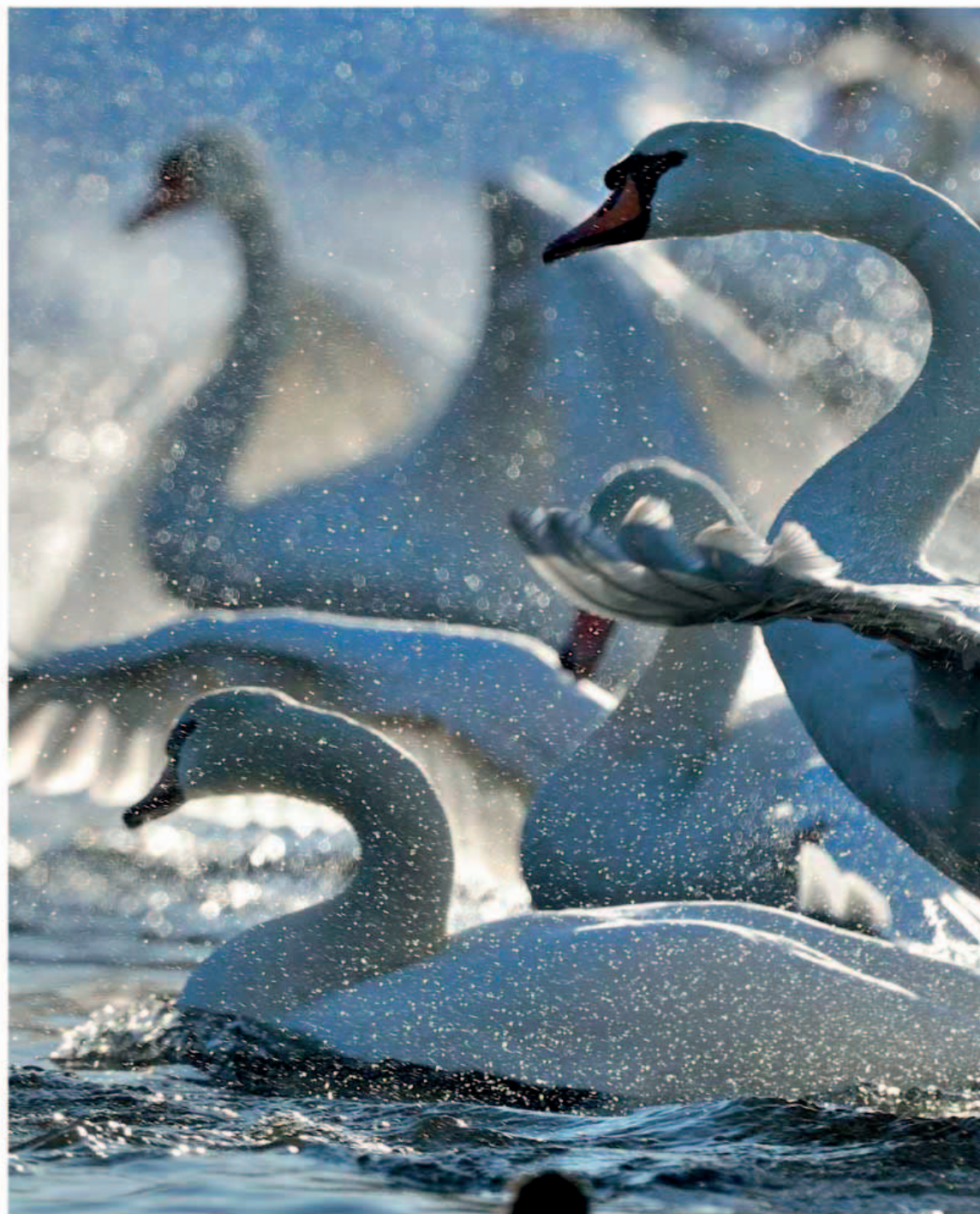
While by no means silent—they make a snakelike hiss when threatened, for example—mute swans are the least vocal of all swans. Other swans make loud, bugling calls when flying, but mute swans stay in touch in flight with a different sound: their wings create a far-carrying, deep, rhythmic, throbbing noise.

Mute swans are powerful enough to have few predators as adults. Although an occasional fox or otter may attack an unwary bird, swans have little need for camouflage. Nor is there much demand for territorial display because their huge size and white color stand out. However, aggressive encounters are frequent. Mute swans will allow younger swans into their territory but chase away competitors. They arch their wing feathers, curve back their necks, and thrust out their chests. A charge toward another swan on water, powered by thrusts of their big webbed feet, is fast and impressive.

Summer flocks

Large flocks of mute swans gather to molt and often to feed in shallow, sheltered water or on open fields. Some of these flocks persist through the summer with many swans, even seemingly fully mature ones, not breeding.

Nesting pairs separate off and defend a territory in spring, building a massive nest of reed stems and other waterside vegetation. The young "ugly ducklings," or cygnets, are drab gray-brown. It takes two to three years for them to turn all-white and develop the bright orange and black bill colors of the adults. Adult males have the thickest necks and biggest bills, with a large basal knob.



The mute swan is one of the **heaviest flying birds** in the world

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
- ⚖ 21–27 lb (9.5–12 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Vegetation, snails
- 🏠



Europe, W. and E. Asia

